

Solutions for Graduate Combinatorics HW

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Due to limited time the following are only **sketches** of full solutions, and in particular these solutions alone wouldn't necessarily constitute a solution worth full marks. I also emphasize that there may exist other (possibly simpler) solutions these problems.

1 HW1

- 1.1 Let $\mathcal{F}$ be an r -uniform set system with the property that $F' \cap F'' \not\subseteq F$ for any distinct $F, F', F'' \in \mathcal{F}$. Prove that $|\mathcal{F}| \leq 1 + \binom{r}{\lfloor r/2 \rfloor}$ (Hint: let $F'' \in \mathcal{F}$ be arbitrary and consider the set system $\{F \cap F'' : F \in \mathcal{F} \setminus \{F''\}\}$) [2].

The set system $\mathcal{F}''$ as suggested in the hint is an antichain: for distinct $F, F' \in \mathcal{F}$, having $F' \cap F'' \subseteq F \cap F''$ would in particular imply $F' \cap F'' \subseteq F$ which we assumed not to be the case. Moreover, this same argument shows $|\mathcal{F}''| = |\mathcal{F} \setminus \{F''\}|$, i.e. that $F \cap F'' \neq F' \cap F''$ for distinct F, F' . Since $\mathcal{F}''$ has ground set F'' of size r , it follows from Sperner's Theorem that $|\mathcal{F}''| \leq \binom{r}{\lfloor r/2 \rfloor}$, and hence

$$|\mathcal{F}| = 1 + |\mathcal{F} \setminus \{F''\}| \leq 1 + \binom{r}{\lfloor r/2 \rfloor}.$$

- 1.5 Prove ?? (Hint: try proving the weaker lower bound of n^{-2^d} to get a feel for the proof idea) [2].

The case $d = 1$ is Dilworth's Theorem. Inductively assume we have proven the result up to some value $d \geq 2$. Let G be a graph and $P_1, \dots, P_d$ posets on $V(G)$ such that $x \sim y$ iff $x <_i y$ or $y <_i x$ for some i . If P_d contains a chain on at least $n^{1/(d+1)}$ elements then this corresponds to a clique of size at least $n^{1/(d+1)}$ in G . By the Corollary of Dilworth's Theorem that $n \leq h(P)w(P)$ for all P , we can assume P_d contains an antichain on at least $n^{d/(d+1)}$ vertices of G . Let $G' \subseteq G$ be the induced subgraph of G on this antichain. Since G' is induced on an antichain of P_d , it follows that $P_1, \dots, P_{d-1}$ are such that two vertices of G' are adjacent if and only if they are comparable by some P_i with $1 \leq i \leq d-1$, so inductively G' has either a clique or independent set of size at least $(n^{d/(d+1)})^{1/d} = n^{1/(d+1)}$, proving the result.

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1.7a Prove Erdős-Szekeres using Dilworth's Theorem [2].

Construct a poset P on $[n]$ where $i <_P j$ if and only if $a_i < a_j$ and $i < j$ (with these latter inequalities being with respect to the usual ordering on $\mathbb{R}$). By Dilworth there exists a chain or an antichain of size at least $\sqrt{n}$ of P , and it is straightforward to check that these correspond to increasing or decreasing subsequences of π of the same size.

1.7b Prove this without using Dilworth's Theorem (Hint: for each j define i_j to be the length of the longest increasing subsequence which ends at a_j and d_j to be the length of the longest decreasing subsequence which ends at a_j . Can we have $(i_j, d_j) = (i_{j'}, d_{j'})$ for $j < j'$?) [2+].

Following the hint, we can not have $(i_j, d_j) = (i_{j'}, d_{j'})$ for $j < j'$: if $a_j < a_{j'}$ then we could add $a_{j'}$ to the end of the increasing subsequence of length i_j ending at a_j to find $i_{j'} > i_j$; an analogous argument works if $a_j > a_{j'}$. It follows that the n pairs (i_j, d_j) are distinct, which means we can not have $i_j, d_j < \sqrt{n}$ for all n and hence some i_j or d_j is at least this large, corresponding to a large increasing or decreasing subsequence.

1.8 Prove Mirsky's Theorem: if $P = (X, \leq)$ is a finite poset of height $h(P)$, then there exists a partition of X into $h(P)$ antichains (Hint: prove that the set of maximal elements M of P form an antichain) [2].

For the hint, if two maximal elements x, y were comparable, say with $x < y$, then x would not be maximal. We conclude that M is indeed an antichain.

We now prove the main result by induction on $h(P)$, the case $h(P) = 0$ being trivial since this can only occur if $P = \emptyset$. We claim that $P - M$ has height at most $h(P) - 1$; indeed, if $P - M$ had a chain of length $h(P)$ then whatever element is at the top of the chain is not maximal and hence could be extended to a chain of length $h(P) + 1$ in P , a contradiction. Inductively then we can decompose $P - M$ into at most $h(P) - 1$ antichains, which together with M gives the desired partition.

2 HW2

1.2b Prove for any integer $t \geq 1$ that

$$\sup_{r \in \mathbb{R}} \Pr\left[\sum_i a_i X_i \in [r, r + 2t]\right] \leq \max_{T \subseteq \{0, 1, \dots, n\}} \sum_{r \in T} \binom{n}{r} 2^{-n},$$

where to be clear this upper bound is equal to 2^{-n} times the sum of the t largest binomial coefficients [2].

As in the Littlewood-Offord proof, we may assume $a_i > 0$ for all i . Fix an arbitrary r and let $\mathcal{F}$ be the set of $F \subseteq [n]$ with the property that $\sum_{i \in F} a_i - \sum_{i \notin F} a_i \in [r, r + t + 1]$. By Erdős's Theorem it suffices to prove that $\mathcal{F}$ does not have a chain of size larger than t . Say for contradiction that it contained some $F_1 \subsetneq \dots \subsetneq F_{t+1}$. Define $\sigma_j = \sum_{i \in F_j} a_i - \sum_{i \notin F_j} a_i$. It is straightforward to prove by induction that $\sigma_j \geq 2(j - 1) + \sigma_1$ since each a_i is at least 1. In particular since $\sigma_1 \geq r$ by hypothesis of $F_1 \in \mathcal{F}$ we find $\sigma_{t+1} \geq 2t + r$, a contradiction to $F_{t+1} \in \mathcal{F}$ implying $\sigma_{t+1} < 2t + r$.

- 2.1 We consider an abstract version of the Katona circle argument: for a permutation $\pi : [n] \rightarrow [n]$, we define for $F = \{x_1, \dots, x_r\} \subseteq [n]$ the set $\pi(F) = \{\pi(x_1), \dots, \pi(x_r)\}$ and for $\mathcal{F} \subseteq 2^{[n]}$ we define $\pi(\mathcal{F}) = \{\pi(F) : F \in \mathcal{F}\}$. Prove that for any two families $\mathcal{F}, \mathcal{A} \subseteq 2^{[n]}$ that

$$\sum_{F \in \mathcal{F}} \frac{|\mathcal{A} \cap \binom{[n]}{|F|}|}{\binom{n}{|F|}} \leq \max_{\pi} |\pi(\mathcal{F}) \cap \mathcal{A}|,$$

where the maximum ranges over all permutations $\pi : [n] \rightarrow [n]$ [2-].

We count all pairs (π, F) with $\pi(F) \in \mathcal{A}$ in two ways. Each of the $n!$ bijections π is trivially in at most $\max_{\pi} |\pi(\mathcal{F}) \cap \mathcal{A}|$ pairs. On the other hand, for each F we can identify (π, F) by specifying the image $\pi(F) \in \mathcal{A} \cap \binom{[n]}{|F|}$ and given this we have $|F|!(n-|F|)! = \frac{n!}{\binom{n}{|F|}}$ ways to specify π . Setting these two counts equal to each other and dividing both sides by $n!$ gives the stated bound.

- 2.2 Give an alternative proof of the LYM inequality by using that if $\mathcal{I}$ is the set of initial intervals $\{1, 2, \dots, i\}$ for $1 \leq i \leq n$ then every antichain of $\mathcal{I}$ has size at most 1 [2-].

This follows from the previous exercise applied with $\mathcal{A} = \mathcal{I}$ after observing that if $\mathcal{F}$ is an antichain, then at most one $F \in \mathcal{F}$ can have $\pi(F)$ an initial interval (since a second F' with, say, $\pi(F')$ an initial interval containing the initial interval $\pi(F)$ would imply $F \subseteq F'$).

- 2.5 We say that a family $\mathcal{F} \subseteq 2^{[n]}$ is union if $F \cup F' \neq [n]$ for all $F, F' \in \mathcal{F}$. Prove that $\mathcal{F}$ is a union family if and only if

$$\overline{\mathcal{F}} := \{[n] \setminus F : F \in \mathcal{F}\}$$

is intersecting. In particular, any problem about intersecting families can be turned into a problem about union families, which in practice can sometimes be easier to solve [1+].

Any $x \in F \cap F'$ satisfies $x \notin ([n] \setminus F) \cup ([n] \setminus F') = [n] \setminus (F \cap F')$, giving the result.

3 HW3

- 2.6a Prove that every maximal intersecting family $\mathcal{F} \subseteq 2^{[n]}$ has $|\mathcal{F}| = 2^{n-1}$. For this we emphasize that by definition, no intersecting family $\mathcal{F}$ can have $\emptyset \in \mathcal{F}$ since then $F \cap F' = \emptyset$ for $F = F' = \emptyset$ elements in $\mathcal{F}$ [2].

Let $\mathcal{F}$ be maximal intersecting. We prove the stronger fact that for every $F \subseteq [n]$ exactly 1 of F or $[n] \setminus F$ is in $\mathcal{F}$. Certainly at most 1 of these sets can be in $\mathcal{F}$ if it is intersecting, so now assume for contradiction that there is some F such that neither is in $\mathcal{F}$. If $\{F\} \cup \mathcal{F}$ is intersecting then this contradicts $\mathcal{F}$ being maximal, so there must be some $F' \in \mathcal{F}$ disjoint from F . This means $F' \subseteq [n] \setminus F$, and this in turn means that $\{[n] \setminus F\} \cup \mathcal{F}$ is intersecting since any F'' disjoint from this would be disjoint with F' .

2.6b Prove that there exist maximal intersecting families $\mathcal{F} \subseteq \binom{[n]}{r}$ with $|\mathcal{F}| \leq 4^r$ for all n, r [2].

We trivially have $|\mathcal{F}| \leq 2^n$ for any family $\mathcal{F}$ so it suffices to prove the result when $n \geq 2r$. There are many possible solutions, the simplest is to take $\mathcal{F} = \binom{[2r-1]}{r}$ which is intersecting but any $F \not\subseteq [2r-1]$ will necessarily intersect $[2r-1]$ in at most $r-1$ vertices and hence be disjoint from some edge in $\mathcal{F}$, so $\mathcal{F}$ is maximal with size at most $2^{2r-1} \leq 4^r$.

2.8 Recall that for a family $\mathcal{F} \subseteq 2^{[n]}$ we define its Lubell measure

$$\lambda(\mathcal{F}) = \sum_{F \in \mathcal{F}} \frac{1}{\binom{n}{|F|}}.$$

Prove that if $\mathcal{F}$ is intersecting then $\lambda(\mathcal{F}) \leq \frac{n+1}{2}$ [2].

Proof without circle method: The key idea is that for each F , at most one of F and $[n] \setminus F$ is in $\mathcal{F}$. The slick way of doing this is:

$$2\lambda(\mathcal{F}) = \sum_{F \in \mathcal{F}} 2 \binom{n}{|F|}^{-1} = \sum_{F \in \mathcal{F}} \binom{n}{|F|}^{-1} + \binom{n}{|[n] \setminus F|}^{-1} \leq \sum_{F \in 2^{[n]}} \binom{n}{|F|}^{-1} = n+1,$$

with the last equality using that each of the $n+1$ layers has Lubell weight 1.

Proof with circle method: Take $\mathcal{A}_n^*$ to be the family of all cyclic intervals except for $[n]$. Any $\mathcal{F} \subseteq \mathcal{A}_n^*$ which is intersecting has size at most $|\mathcal{A}_n^*| = \binom{n}{2}$ again simply because an intersecting family can not contain both a set and its complement. Applying the abstract Katona circle argument from Exercise 2.1 then yields that any intersecting $\mathcal{F} \subseteq 2^{[n]} \setminus [n]$ has $\lambda(\mathcal{F}) = \sum_F \binom{n}{|F|}^{-1} \leq \frac{n-1}{2}$, and this in turn implies that any intersecting $\mathcal{F} \subseteq 2^{[n]}$ has $\lambda(\mathcal{F}) \leq 1 + \frac{n-1}{2}$ since $\lambda([n]) = 1$.

We emphasize that a direct argument with $\mathcal{A}_n$ instead of $\mathcal{A}_n^*$ does not quite work out because $|\mathcal{A}_n \cap \binom{[n]}{n}|$ does not equal n like in all the other terms but rather 1.